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Zalo

me.grow

RMIT University Vietnam, Saigon South Campus



Topic 8: Correcting Behavior Through Coaching

How to address difficult behavior with clarity, confidence and car

Dr Thao Luong

About this session

Becoming a manager changes the conversations you are responsible for.

For the first time, you are not only responsible for your own performance, you are responsible for setting expectations, giving feedback, addressing behaviour, and helping others succeed.

Some of these conversations will feel uncomfortable. This session helps you approach them with clarity, confidence and care, using coaching to create reflection and ownership, while remaining clear about expectations and accountability.

By the end of this session, you will:

- Recognize behavior that needs your attention and address it early;
- Raise difficult issues clearly without attacking the person;
- Use questions to help people reflect, take ownership and find a better way forward;
- Be supportive while remaining clear about standards and expected change.

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Agenda

1. **Notice**: “What should I address?”
2. **Converse**: Raise difficult issues clearly and manage your emotions
3. **Coach**: Use questions to create reflection and ownership
4. **Hold Accountable**: Stay supportive while remaining clear about expected changes



About me ☺



Dr. Thao Luong

Senior Program Manager – Lecturer
(Human Resource Management)

E-mail: thao.luong3@rmit.edu.vn

Education:

- Ph.D. in Knowledge Science, Japan Advanced Institute of Science and Technology (Japan)
- Master in HRM, Griffith University (Australia)
- Bachelor in Business, University of Economics HCMC (Vietnam)
- CHT & CHE (American Hotel and Lodging Educational Institute)
- Trained Facilitator in the LEGO® Serious Play® Methodology

Work Experience (15 years): Sales (PepsiCo International), HR (FrieslandCampina), Corporate Training (Saigontourist Group), VP (Saigontourist Hospitality College)

Our Playbook





- Be fully present
- Try to earn the playground money for your team
- Honor others' opinions
- Put cellphones away and on vibrate (if possible)
- Please don't hurt anyone
- Use **burning** thoughts for questions
- Relax and have fun
- "Through discipline comes freedom" - Aristotle



1. Notice:

“What should I address?”



NOTICE starts with the role shift

As a manager, what you tolerate becomes information for the team.

My work	→	**Our work**
My standards	→	**Team standards**
My relationships	→	**Fairness across relationships**
My discomfort	→	**My responsibility to act**

Manager question: “Is this something I am uncomfortable with or something the team genuinely needs me to address?”

Discussion Activity: Notice or let it go?

Decide first. Then explain what signal your choice sends to the team.

A A usually reliable employee is 10 minutes late once.

B A strong performer repeatedly interrupts junior colleagues.

C Two colleagues disagree strongly about a technical approach.

D A team member publicly mocks another person's suggestion.

E Someone prefers a different working style from yours.

F A team member repeatedly ignores an agreed team process.



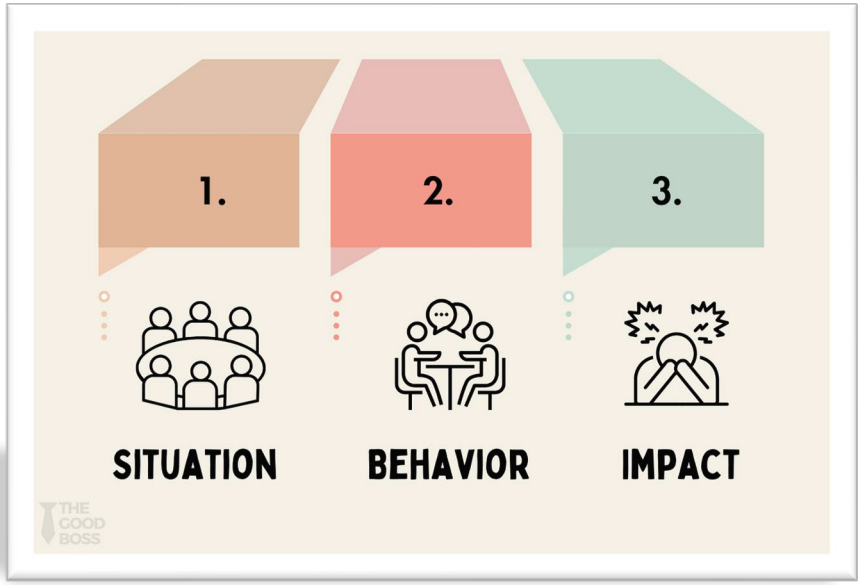
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The 5-Impact Test

Adapted for this workshop from the Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI) feedback framework (Center for Creative Leadership)

When deciding whether a behavior needs addressing, consider:

- **PERFORMANCE**
  Does it affect results, quality, productivity or delivery?
- **PEOPLE**
  Does it affect colleagues, workload, wellbeing or collaboration?
- **CULTURE**
  Does it reinforce or undermine the behaviors we expect?
- **TRUST**
  Does it affect reliability, credibility or working relationships?
- **POLICY / ETHICS**
  Does it create a compliance, fairness, safety or ethical concern?



The SBI Feedback Model is a structured framework developed by the Center for Creative Leadership

Discussion Activity: Notice or let it go?

Decide first. Then explain what signal your choice sends to the team.

A A usually reliable employee is 10 minutes late once.

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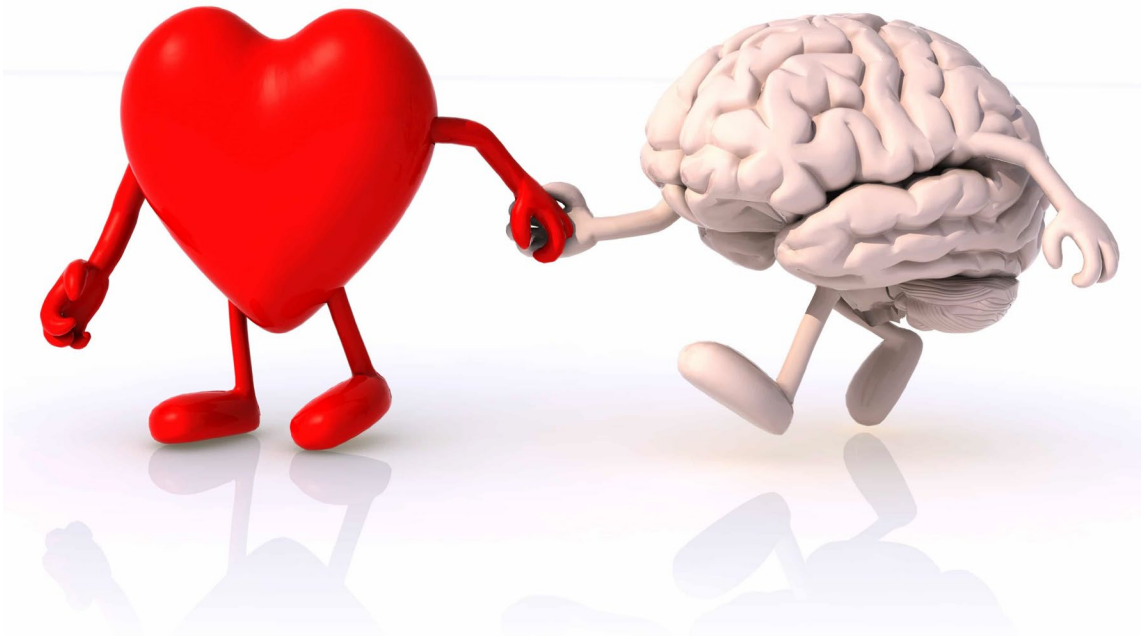
E Someone prefers a different working style from yours.

F A team member repeatedly ignores an agreed team process.

Not every irritation needs correction, but repeated or harmful behavior should not be normalized by silence.

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2. Converse:
Raise difficult issues clearly and manage your emotions



CONVERSE starts with what you can observe

The first sentence often determines whether the conversation opens or closes.

PERSON / JUDGEMENT

“You're disrespectful and difficult.”

BEHAVIOUR / OBSERVATION

“In today's meeting, you interrupted Lan three times while she was presenting.”

Then make the standard visible:

“I want us to challenge ideas strongly, and I expect us to let colleagues finish and respond to the idea, not the person.”

Camera test: could a camera or microphone have captured what you are describing?

Activity: Rewrite the opening

Make each opening specific, neutral and clear about the standard (behavior).

“You've got a bad attitude.”	→	Rewrite here: observation + standard
“Everyone thinks you're difficult.”	→	Rewrite here: observation + standard
“Can you be more professional?”	→	Rewrite here: observation + standard
“You always make meetings unpleasant.”	→	Rewrite here: observation + standard

Pair check: Is it observable? Is it free of labels? Is the expectation clear?





At this stage, also try to manage your emotions

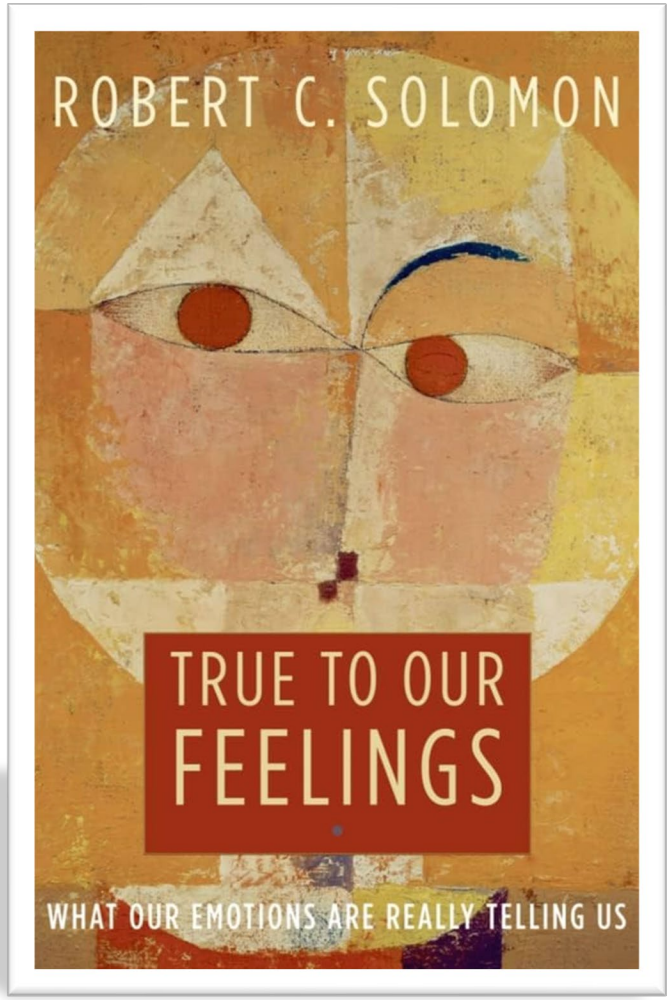
What are Emotions?

Definition

- Emotions are psychological and physiological responses to situations that matter to us.
- They influence how we think, feel, and act.

In simple terms, emotions:

- are signals about what we are experiencing
- shape our attention and interpretation
- affect our reactions, decisions, and relationships
- can help or hinder us, depending on how we manage them



Activity: Emotion Check-In

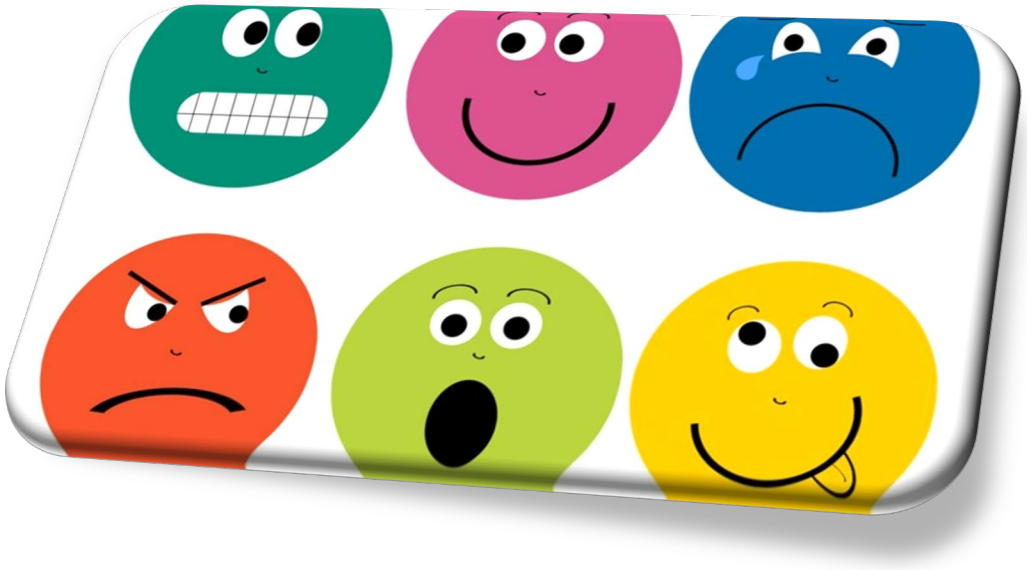
Notice how emotions show up in leadership and influence our responses at work.

Instructions

Think of a recent work situation where you felt a strong emotion as a leader or colleague. It could be frustration, pressure, disappointment, pride, anxiety, or excitement.

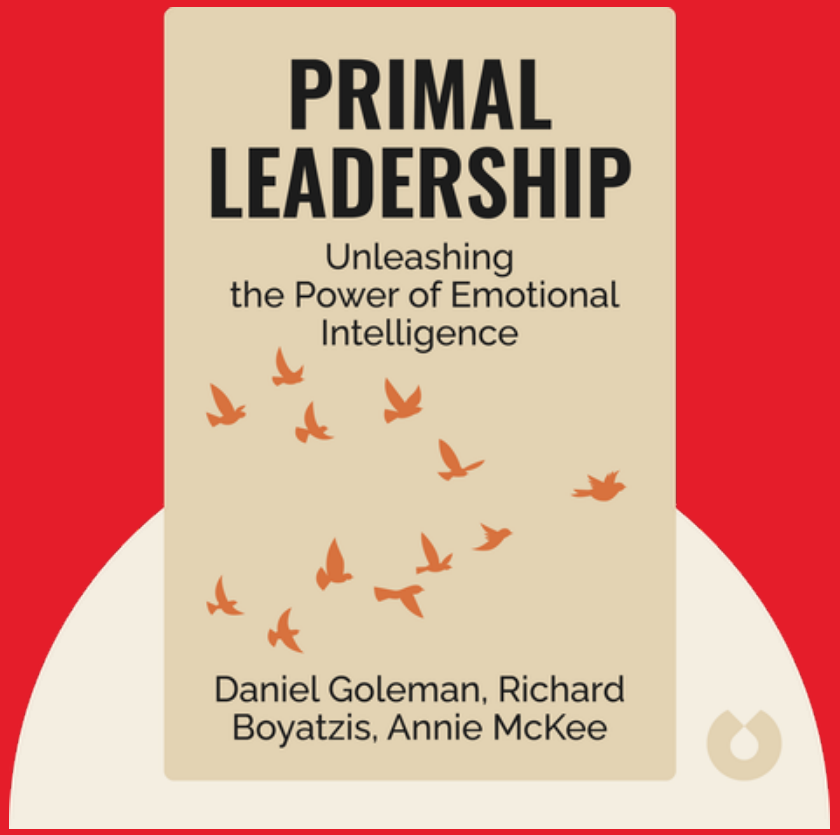
Reflect on these questions:

- What happened?
- How/What did you feel?
- How did that emotion affect your response?



Process

- 2 minutes individual reflection
- 3 minutes pair sharing
- Be ready to share one insight with the room



Debrief message

- Emotions are always present in leadership.
- Emotional intelligence begins with noticing them before they start shaping our behavior unconsciously.

What is Emotional Intelligence (EI)?

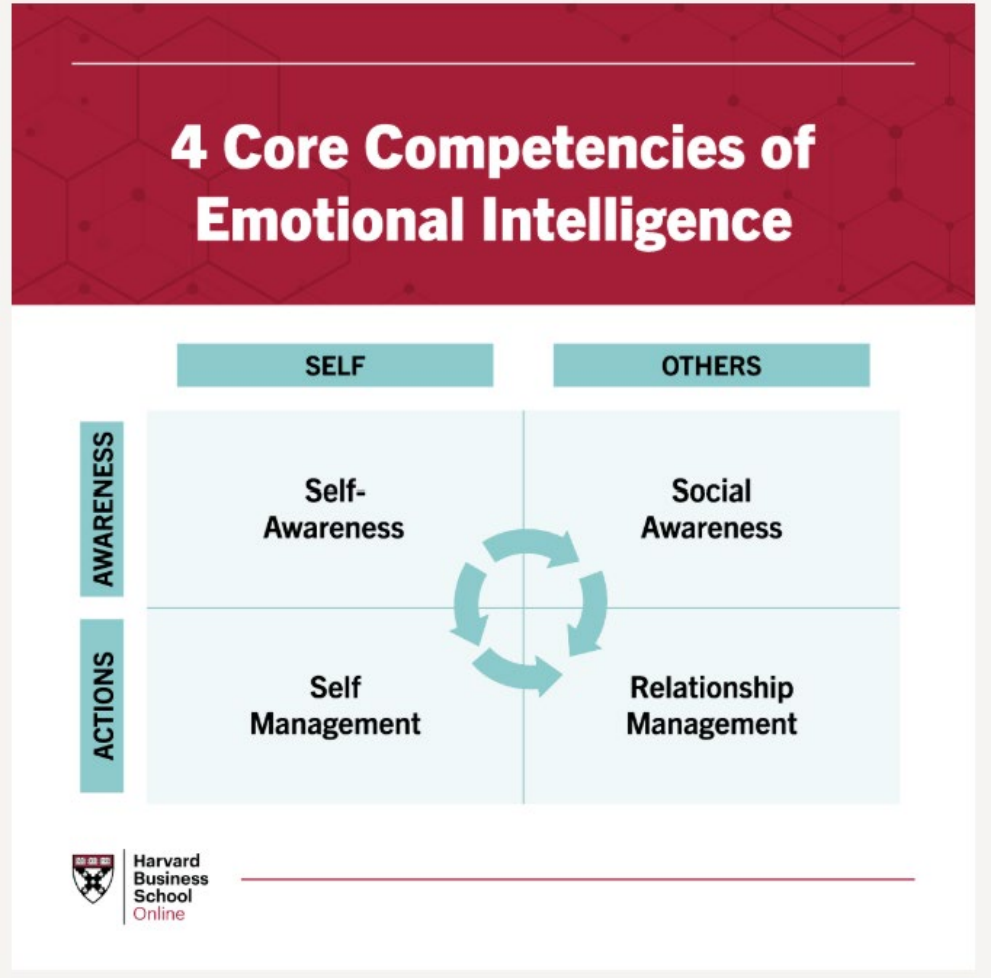
Definition

EI is the ability to recognize, understand, manage, and use emotions effectively in ourselves and in our interactions with others

Emotional intelligence includes the ability to:

- notice what we are feeling
- understand how emotions affect our thoughts and behavior
- regulate our responses in constructive ways
- recognize emotions in others
- respond in ways that support trust, communication, and relationships

(Grewal et al., 2006)



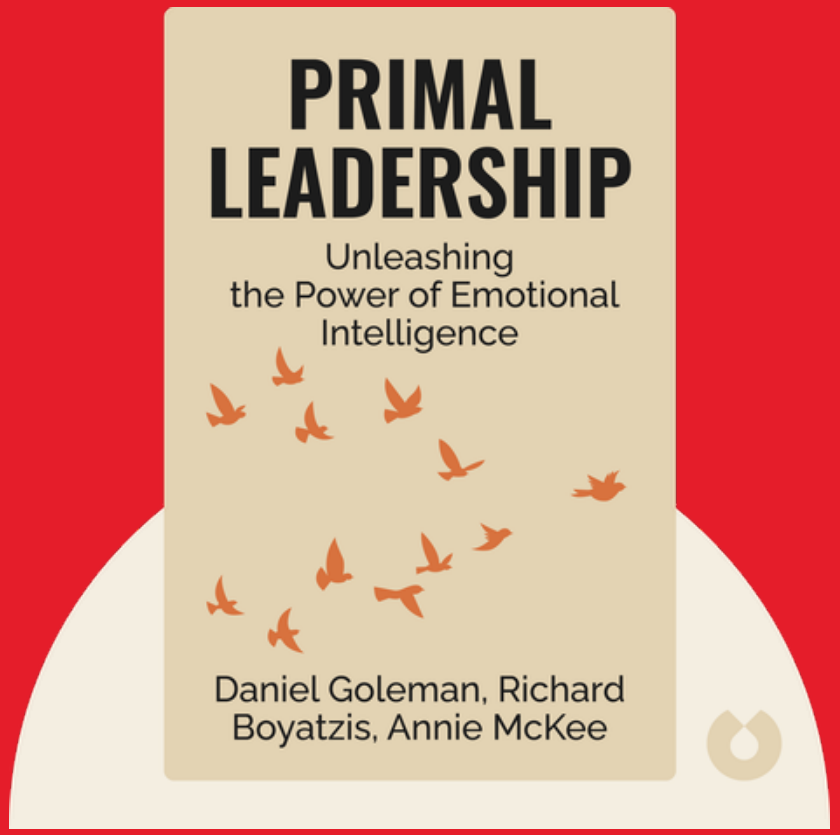
Activity: Video Observation (Group Activity)

How emotional intelligence shows up in leadership behavior and workplace interaction.

Discussion questions

1. What emotions did you notice in the interaction?
2. What signs of high or low emotional intelligence did you observe?
3. How did emotions influence communication and behavior?
4. How might the interaction have gone differently with stronger emotional intelligence?
5. What leadership lessons can we take from this example?





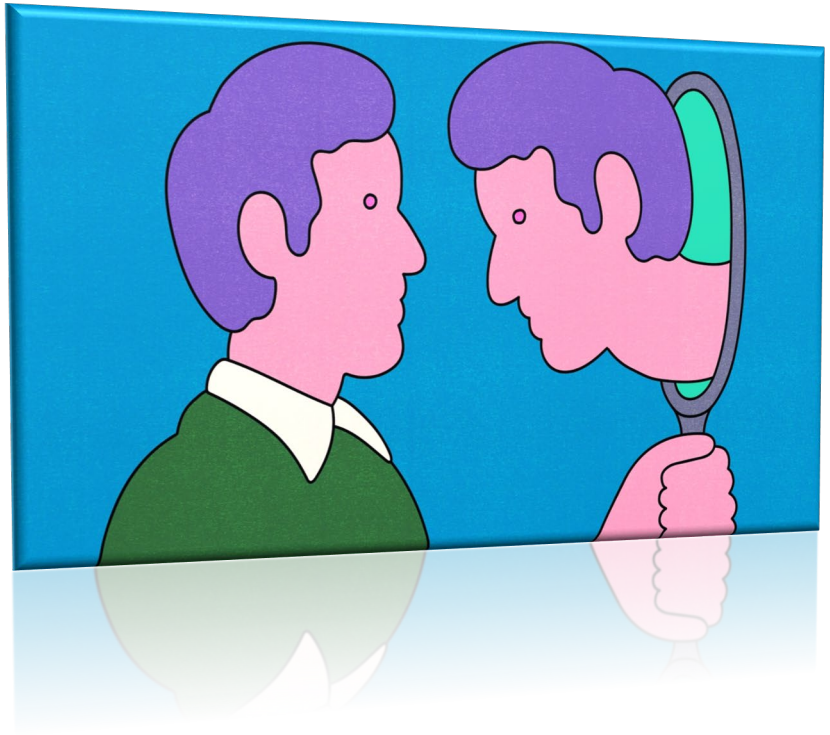
Debrief message

- Emotional intelligence becomes visible in how leaders respond, communicate, and influence others in real situations.

Self-Awareness and Self-Management

Two core intrapersonal foundations are:

- **Self-awareness:** noticing feelings, intuition, and inner signals
- **Self-management:** managing emotions, attitudes, and behavior more effectively



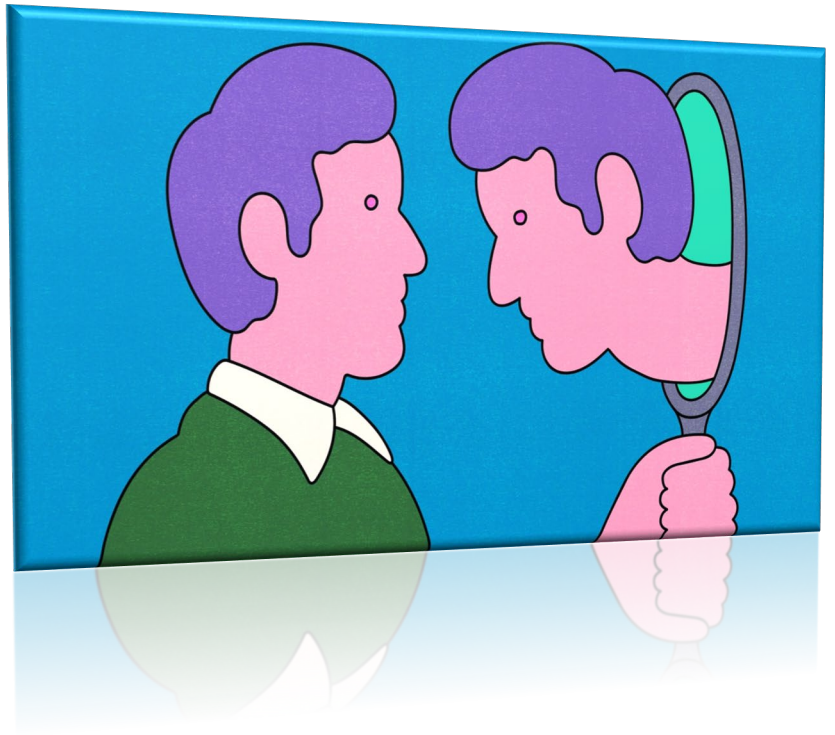
These two are closely linked:

- self-awareness helps us recognize what we feel
- self-management helps us act constructively under pressure
- together, they support better performance and stronger relationships

(Neale et al., 2009)

Self-Awareness

Self-awareness is being in touch with your feelings, intuition, and the signals your body is sending you.



People with stronger self-awareness are more able to:

- notice what they are feeling in the moment
- recognize emotional triggers
- understand where emotions show up in the body
- connect emotions to underlying attitudes, beliefs, or values
- learn from emotional patterns instead of repeating them automatically

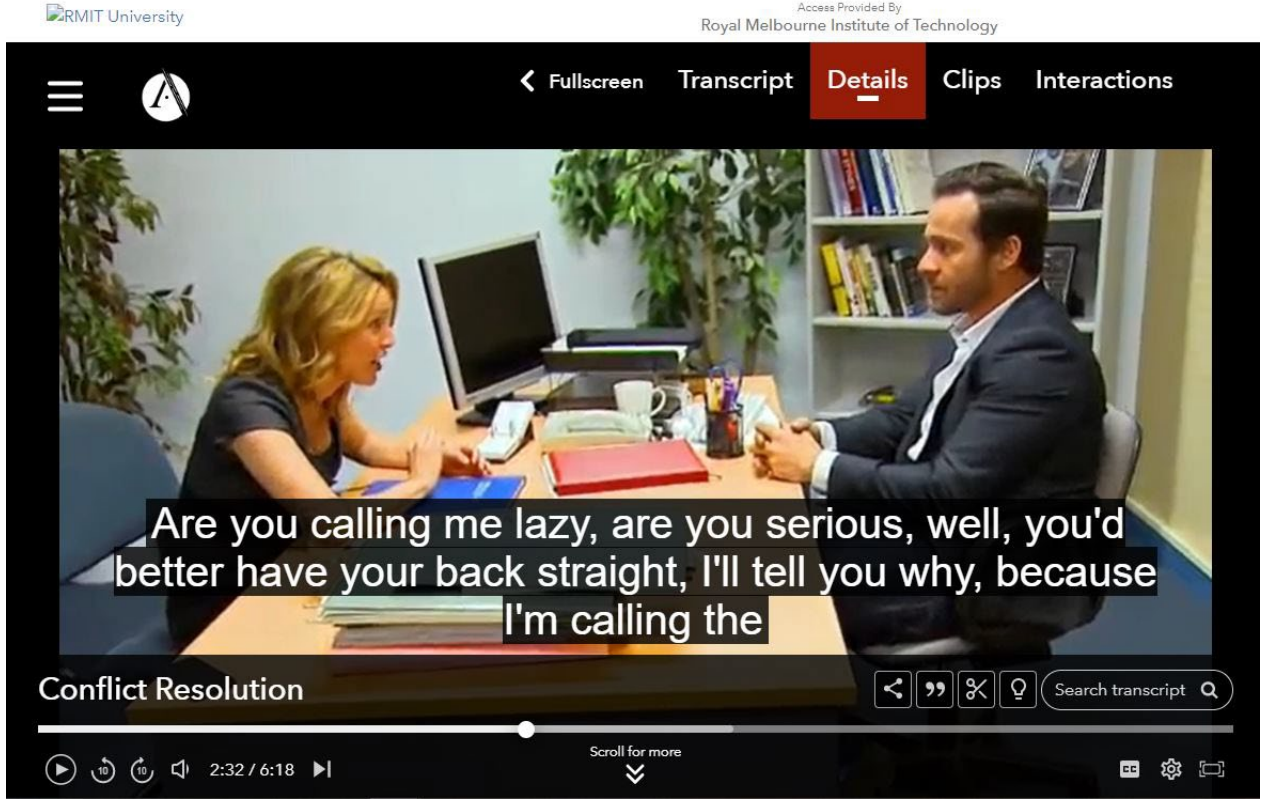
(Neale et al., 2009)

Activity : Self-Awareness Through Emotional

As you watch the video, do not focus only on the facts of the case.
Pay attention to your own emotional response.

Self-awareness questions after watching:

1. What emotion am I feeling right now?
2. What is triggering this reaction in me?
3. What personal values does this response reflect?
4. If I were to react immediately, what might I do?
5. What would a more self-aware and self-managed response look like?



What is Self-Management?

Definition
Self-management is the ability to regulate emotions, manage impulses, and respond in constructive ways, especially under pressure.

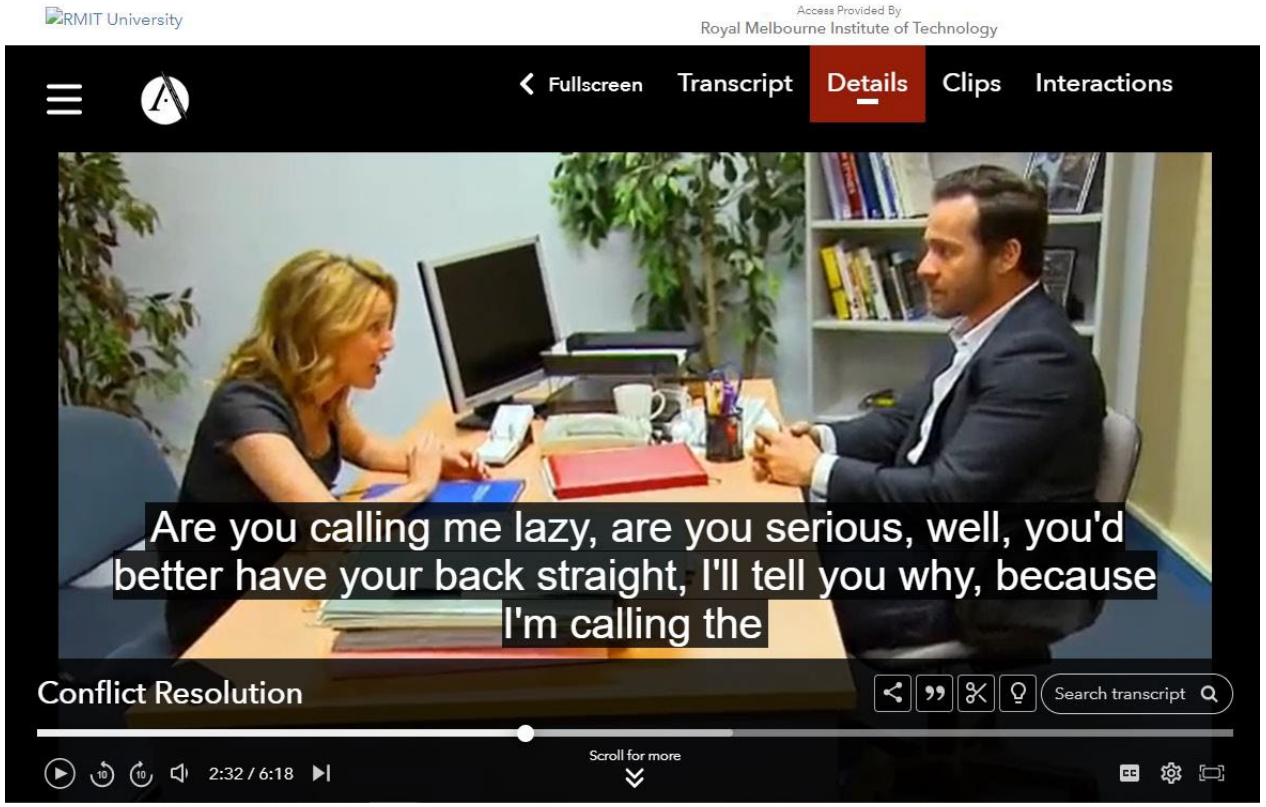


Self-management helps leaders to:

- stay calm in difficult situations
- pause before reacting
- respond thoughtfully rather than emotionally
- remain focused and disciplined
- act in ways that support trust and effectiveness

(Neale et al., 2009)

Activity 6: Self Management in Action



Group Discussion:

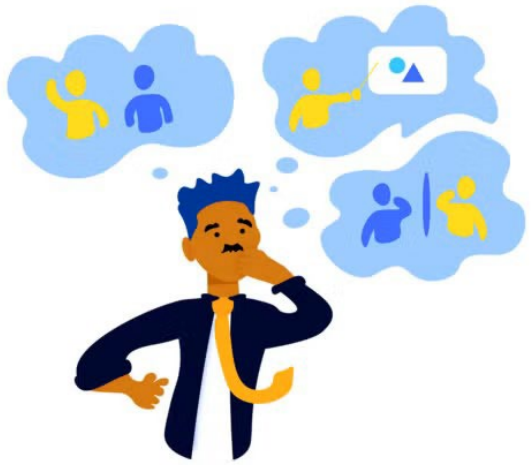
As Jeff, how would you handle the situation differently?

Why Self-Awareness and Self-Management Matter

Thoughts, feelings, and actions are always connected, and they shape performance.

- Emotions are involved in every action, decision, and judgment
- Whatever the situation, we are always **thinking, feeling, and doing**
- Attitudes influence emotions, and emotions influence behavior
- When emotions take over thinking, we can experience an **emotional hijack**

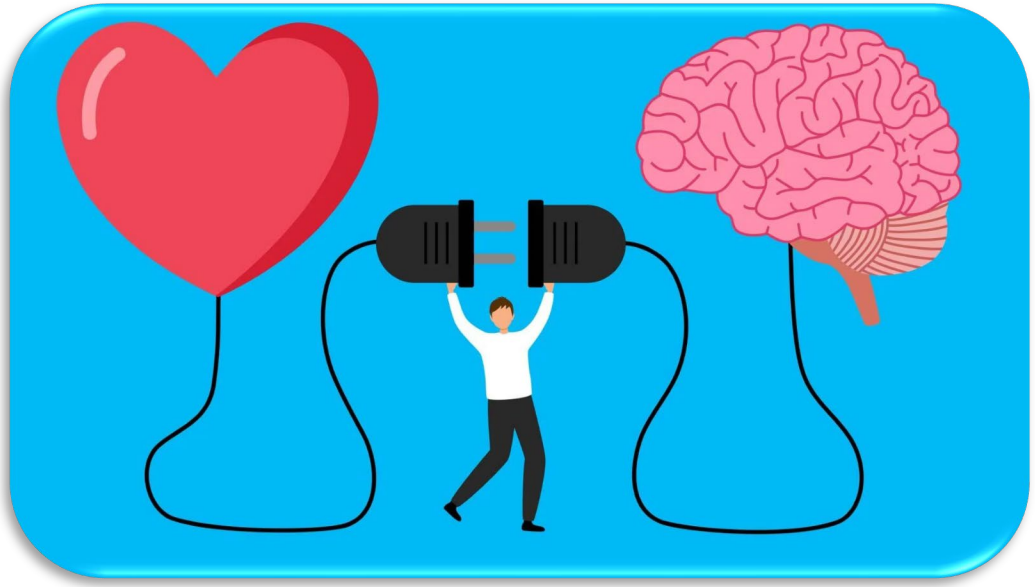
(Neale et al., 2009)



Leadership Implications

Without self-awareness and self-management, leaders may:

- react habitually rather than thoughtfully
- let frustration, fear, or defensiveness drive behavior
- reduce trust, clarity, and effectiveness



With stronger self-awareness and self-management, leaders are better able to:

- pause
- interpret what they are feeling
- manage their response
- act more constructively under pressure

(Neale et al., 2009)

CONVERSE starts with what you can observe

The first sentence often determines whether the conversation opens or closes.

PERSON / JUDGEMENT

“You're disrespectful and difficult.”

BEHAVIOUR / OBSERVATION

“In today's meeting, you interrupted Lan three times while she was presenting.”

Then make the standard visible:

“I want us to challenge ideas strongly, and I expect us to let colleagues finish and respond to the idea, not the person.”

Your EI also contributes to the effectiveness of your action at this stage.

3. Coach:
Use questions to create reflection and ownership



What is coaching for behavioral change?

A line-manager approach: create reflection and ownership while remaining clear about the standard.

COACHING = helping someone THINK so they can CHANGE

SEE

Recognise what I did

→

REFLECT

Understand the impact

→

OWN

Take responsibility

→

CHANGE

Choose a better behavior

Managerial coaching: the manager acts as a facilitator of workplace learning, enabling employees to learn, develop and improve performance.

Sources: Ellinger et al. (2011), definition reproduced/discussed in Turner et al. (2023), Frontiers in Psychology; CIPD (2025).

Coaching is not the same as being “soft”

For behavioral correction, coaching sits inside a clear management conversation.

TELLING	“Don't do that again.”	**CLARIFYING**	Make the behavior and standard visible.
JUDGING	“You have a bad attitude.”	**QUESTIONING**	Help the employee examine what happened.
EXCUSING	“I understand, so it's okay.”	**LISTENING + CHALLENGING**	Explore perspective without abandoning the standard.
FIXING	“Here's exactly what you should do.”	**OWNERSHIP**	Let the employee articulate a better response.

The manager provides clarity about WHAT needs to change. Coaching helps the employee work through HOW to change it.

CIPD (2025): workplace coaching uses one-to-one conversations to enhance skills, knowledge or work performance and focuses on specific skills and goals.

Activity: Intention ≠ impact

Practise moving the conversation forward without debating whether the person “meant it.”

EMPLOYEE

“I was only joking. I didn't mean to offend anyone.”

MANAGER

Acknowledge intention → refocus on impact → ask for an alternative

In pairs: create a 2-3 sentence response. Then swap with a new employee line:

Listening as Emotional Intelligence

Listening is more than hearing words; it is how leaders show attention, respect, and understanding

(Neale et al., 2009).

Common barriers to listening, such as:

- getting distracted by inner thoughts
- planning what to say next
- interrupting
- listening through labels or preconceptions
- turning the conversation back to yourself
- dismissing or trivializing others' concerns
- giving answers too quickly



Three Levels of Listening

Three levels of listening:

1. Factual listening

- listening for facts and information
- useful when clarifying arrangements or details

2. Emotional listening

- listening for emotions, tone of voice, pauses, and non-verbal cues
- most useful when trying to truly understand the other person

3. Intuitive listening

- paying attention to your own gut sense during the conversation
- useful when something feels inconsistent or incomplete

(Neale et al., 2009)



Questioning to Understand Others

- Questioning is crucial for understanding others
- Open questions are more helpful than closed questions
- Closed questions often keep people closed
- Questions can be used not only to get information for ourselves, but also to help others generate useful insight for themselves.



Examples of open questions:

- How are you feeling about this situation?
- What matters most to you here?
- What do you think is making this difficult?
- What would help most right now?

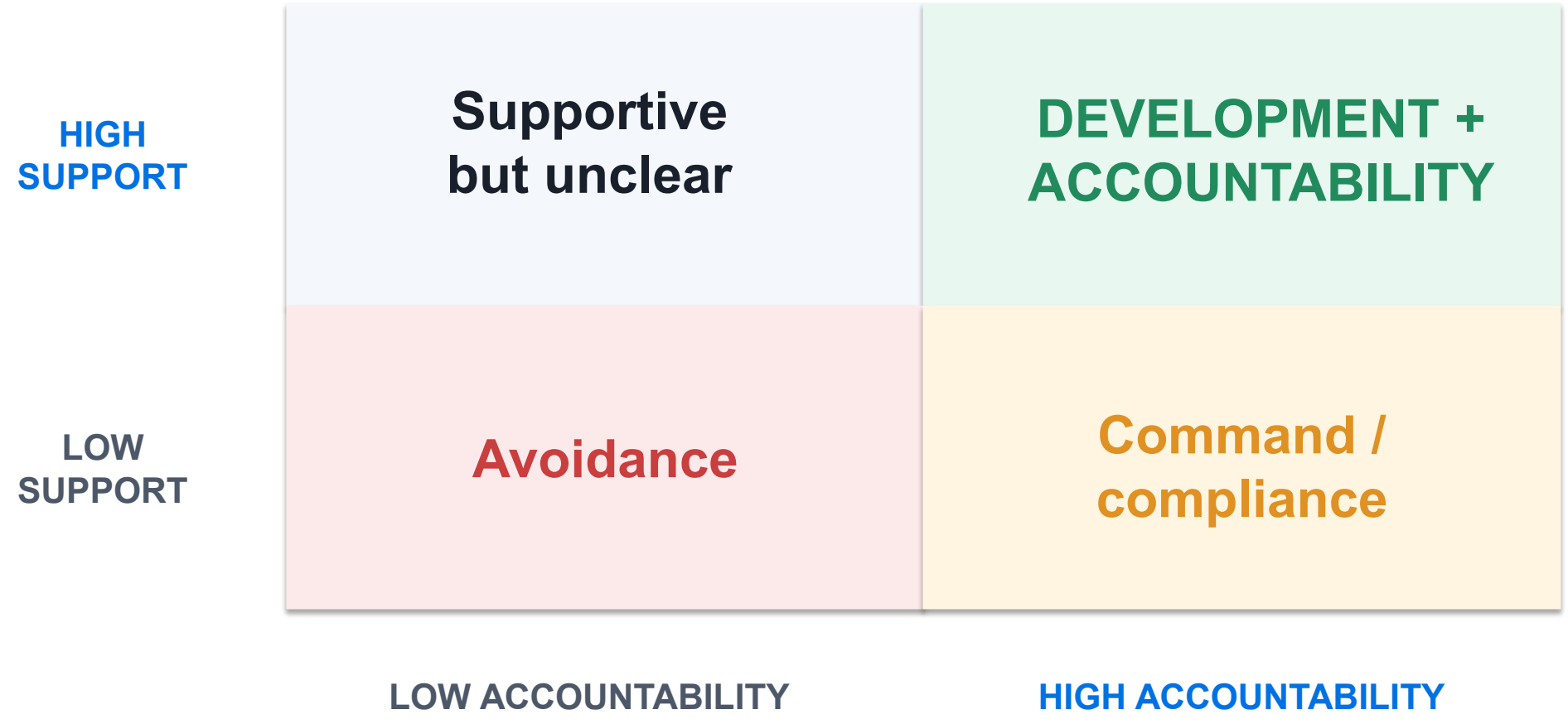
4. Hold Accountable:

Stay supportive while remaining clear about expected changes



HOLD ACCOUNTABLE: support + standard

Coaching creates ownership. Accountability makes the expected change explicit.



When they push back

Do not win the argument. Keep the conversation on behaviour, impact and expectation.

“That's not what happened.”

“Everyone does it.”

“Why are you picking on me?”

“She started it.”

“I'm just being honest.”

“Fine. I won't say anything anymore.”

LISTEN → **ACKNOWLEDGE** → **REFOCUS** → **HOLD THE LINE**

“I hear that you value being direct. I want you to keep challenging ideas. I am asking you to change how you express disagreement with colleagues.”

HOLD ACCOUNTABLE

Turn “I'll do better” into an agreement

A behavioral commitment should be observable enough to follow up.

VAGUE

“I'll communicate better.”

SPECIFIC

“In meetings, I will let people finish and challenge the idea rather than comment on the person.”

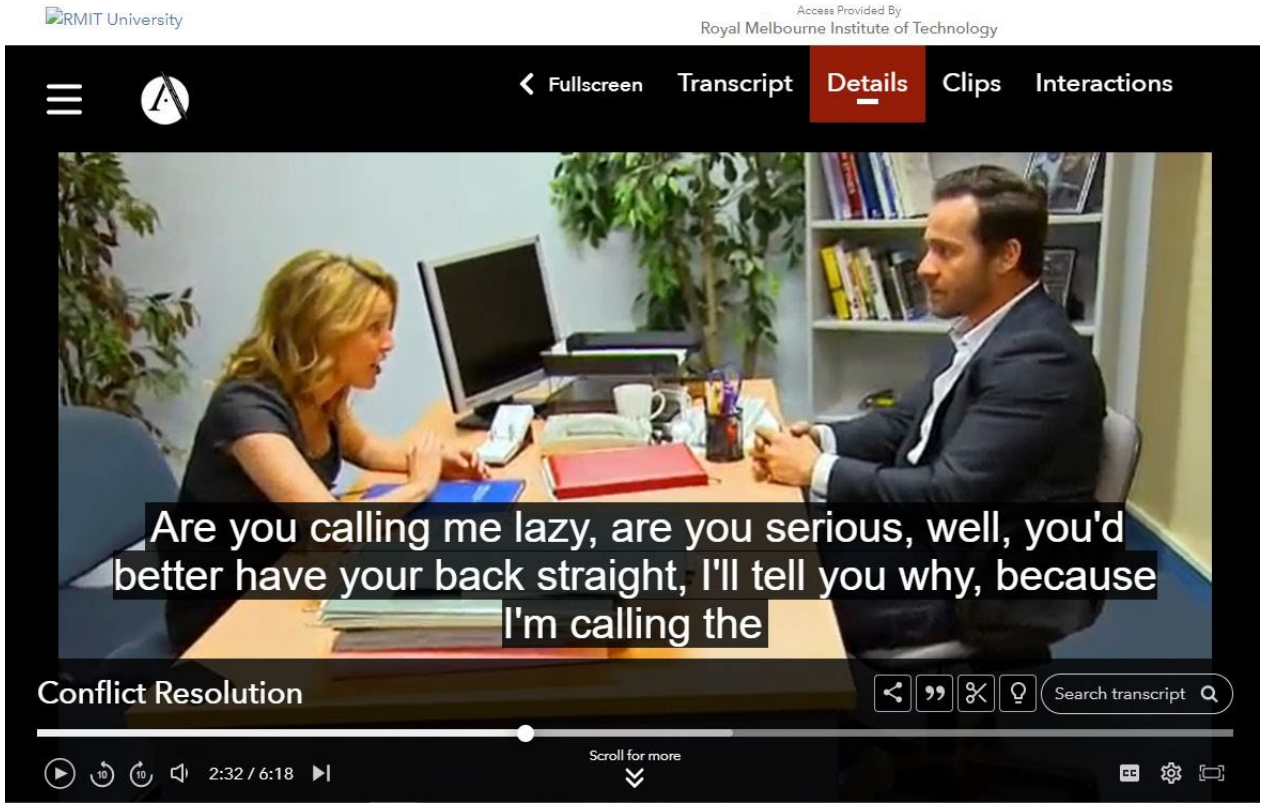
Close with three things:

1. **Expected behaviour**
2. **When / where it applies**
3. **When you will follow up**

Accountability is not a threat. It is clarity about what needs to happen next.



Role-play and Practice



Group Discussion:

As Jeff, how would you handle the situation differently?

The whole conversation

NOTICE → CONVERSE → COACH → HOLD ACCOUNTABLE

NOTICE

This behaviour needs attention.

→

CONVERSE

“Here is what I observed, and here is the standard.”

→

COACH

“What happened? What was the impact? What could you do differently?”

→

HOLD ACCOUNTABLE

“Let's agree exactly what changes and when we will follow up.”

Important: serious misconduct, harassment, discrimination, retaliation, or major ethical/security concerns should follow the appropriate escalation process.



ACTION PLAN

My first 90 days

Choose one habit under each learning outcome.

NOTICE	One behaviour I will address earlier…
CONVERSE	One phrase I will stop using / start using…
COACH	One question I will use more often…
HOLD ACCOUNTABLE	One follow-up habit I will build…

Clarity + curiosity + follow-through = trust in your management.



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Thank you!

Name: Dr. Thao Luong

Position title: Senior Program Manager, Lecturer (HRM)

Email address: thao.luong3@rmit.edu.vn

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Ready for what's next